

# Some Suggested Modifications and Additions for the CSAC Fall Survey

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## 1 Overview

In this document, I will provide some suggestions for designing the CSAC fall survey. These include modifications to the existing survey questions, additions to the survey, and justifications/rationales for these additions along with sample survey instruments where applicable. This document is organized in sections relating to different topics of interest.

## 2 Academic Experiences

A cursory examination of the data from the spring CSAC survey suggests disparities in the academic experiences and goals among LGBTQ+ students. For example, they are more likely to major in humanities and less likely to major in Engineering, more worried about experiencing discrimination in college, feel less prepared for college, and were more likely to be bullied in high school than their non-queer peers. Given this, a more in-depth examination of the academic experiences of LGBTQ+ students in college would provide important insights into these disparities.

### 2.1 Elicitation of Major

Here I present some modifications to the survey instrument we used to elicit expected college majors in the spring survey. The modified instrument includes a 2-step process: first, ask the student how many majors they have to account for students with more than one major; second, ask the student their major(s).

### 2.1.1 Instrument: Number of Majors

*How many majors have you declared/plan to declare?*

- *1*
- *2*
- *3 or more*

Depending on the response, use conditional logic to display the following question the appropriate number of times to elicit major(s).

### 2.1.2 Instrument: Major Elicitation

*What is your major?*

- *Business (e.g. finance, accounting, business administration)*
- *Engineering*
- *Computer science*
- *Math*
- *Biological sciences*
- *Other natural sciences (e.g. physics, chemistry)*
- *Economics*
- *Other social sciences (e.g. sociology, psychology)*
- *Humanities (e.g. history, English)*
- *Arts (e.g. Visual & Studio Art, Music)*
- *Health sciences (e.g. nursing, pharmaceutical sciences)*
- *Education*
- *Applied sciences (e.g., automotive repair, HVAC, construction)*
- *Public service (e.g., criminal justice, fire science)*

- *Undecided*
- *If none of the above accurately describes your major, please describe: (text response)*

Rationale:

- A finer classification of majors is appropriate for current college students, and allows us to gather more accurate information
- Listing out each of the components of STEM fields separately helps us gather more detailed information on STEM majors, especially with regard to disparities among LGBTQ students
  - The culture and environment in different fields within STEM can be very different, e.g. computer science has much more LGBTQ representation than engineering. Combining them together would lose important heterogeneity.
  - We should list math separately because it is an important field within STEM and has known gender disparities.
- Biological sciences has different patterns of gender composition from other sciences
- Economics is qualitatively very different from other social science disciplines such as sociology and psychology, and elicits very different mental associations in many people.
  - Many young LGBTQ people hold hostile attitudes towards economics as a field
  - Studying disparities in economic majors among different social groups helps us understand the pipeline that leads to the disparities in the profession
- Humanities and Arts are distinct enough to warrant being listed separately

### **2.1.3 Instrument: Switching Majors/Major History**

Gathering information on whether and why students have switched majors and their past major history helps us understand the different paths that students take in college, and the reasons for such paths.

Proposed Instrument:

*How many times have you changed your major?*

- *I have never changed my major*
- *1 time*
- *2 times*
- *3 or more times*

Using conditional logic, we can elicit major history. For this purpose, specificity of the major would be needed, therefore text response may be an appropriate option.

### **2.1.4 Instrument: Reasons for Switching Majors**

Elicit for each past major:

*What was the reason that you decided to leave your past major?*

- *The courses were too difficult/demanding*
- *I lost interest in the field*
- *I wanted a major with better earnings potential*
- *I did not like the culture/environment of the department/major*
- *I experienced discrimination/harassment/unfair treatment from faculty*
- *I experienced discrimination/harassment/unfair treatment from other students*

This questions provides detailed information on reasons we might observe disparities among LGBTQ students and other social groups in different majors.

## **2.2 Academic Support and Resources**

Asking students about their knowledge and utilization of academic support resources can provide insight into students' academic experience, and can shed light on disparities among different campuses as well as social identities.

Some other interesting questions might include the following:

- Asking if the student has peers who they can turn to for academic support
- Asking if the student has faculty members who they can turn to for academic support

## 2.3 Beliefs on Wages

Students might hold incorrect beliefs about the distribution of wages for a given major, which might affect their decision to pursue these majors and seek employment in the field. It could provide interesting information to elicit students' beliefs on the range and mean of the wage distribution for their major. Note that the wage distribution is different for different abilities and identities, so we need to take that into account when designing the instrument. For example, an example question could be: what do you think is the average salary for someone of average ability and is the same gender as you in your major?

In addition, it could also be interesting to ask students the wages they expect to earn themselves.

## 3 Social Experiences

### 3.1 Social Belonging

#### 3.1.1 Instrument: Additions to Social Belonging Questions

- *I feel like I belong in my campus community*
- *I feel like I belong in my major/department*

### 3.2 Instrument: Social Support

Social support can influence the social and academic experiences of college students. There might also be disparities among LGBTQ students in regards to the social support they have. There are many validated survey instruments to elicit social support, however most of them include many items and are thus impractical for our purposes. The following two instruments, however, might be of interest since they are shorter:

1. SSQ-6 (Aaronson and Mazumder, 2011): This is a 6-item shortened version of the original SSQ (Social Support Questionnaire) instrument by the same authors. The main disadvantage is that each item includes 2 questions and might be impractical.

2. Social Support Instrument by RAND Corporation.<sup>1</sup> This is an 8-question instru-

| <b>Emotional/informational support</b>                                       | None of the time        | A little of the time    | Some of the time        | Most of the time        | All of the time         |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|-------------------------|-------------------------|-------------------------|-------------------------|
| Someone you can count on to listen to you when you need to talk              | <input type="radio"/> 1 | <input type="radio"/> 2 | <input type="radio"/> 3 | <input type="radio"/> 4 | <input type="radio"/> 5 |
| Someone to give you information to help you understand a situation           | <input type="radio"/> 1 | <input type="radio"/> 2 | <input type="radio"/> 3 | <input type="radio"/> 4 | <input type="radio"/> 5 |
| Someone to give you good advice about a crisis                               | <input type="radio"/> 1 | <input type="radio"/> 2 | <input type="radio"/> 3 | <input type="radio"/> 4 | <input type="radio"/> 5 |
| Someone to confide in or talk to about yourself or your problems             | <input type="radio"/> 1 | <input type="radio"/> 2 | <input type="radio"/> 3 | <input type="radio"/> 4 | <input type="radio"/> 5 |
| Someone whose advice you really want                                         | <input type="radio"/> 1 | <input type="radio"/> 2 | <input type="radio"/> 3 | <input type="radio"/> 4 | <input type="radio"/> 5 |
| Someone to share your most private worries and fears with                    | <input type="radio"/> 1 | <input type="radio"/> 2 | <input type="radio"/> 3 | <input type="radio"/> 4 | <input type="radio"/> 5 |
| Someone to turn to for suggestions about how to deal with a personal problem | <input type="radio"/> 1 | <input type="radio"/> 2 | <input type="radio"/> 3 | <input type="radio"/> 4 | <input type="radio"/> 5 |
| Someone who understands your problems                                        | <input type="radio"/> 1 | <input type="radio"/> 2 | <input type="radio"/> 3 | <input type="radio"/> 4 | <input type="radio"/> 5 |

ment.

Which of these we decide to use depends on the importance we place on understanding social support of students. We can also devise our own instruments which can be shorter.

### 3.3 Instrument: Experiencing Discrimination/Harassment

A Likert scale instrument: never, rarely, occasionally, somewhat often, very often

*How often have you experienced discrimination/harassment based on the following:*

- *Race*
- *Gender Identity*
- *Gender Expression*
- *Religion*
- *Sexual Orientation*

### 3.4 Mental Health

There is evidence that LGBTQ people experience worse mental health outcomes than their peers, and learning about the mental health of students can shed light on the patterns and disparities in mental health among them. In particular, it would be interesting to study

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<sup>1</sup>[https://www.rand.org/health-care/surveys\\_tools/mos/social-support/survey-instrument.html](https://www.rand.org/health-care/surveys_tools/mos/social-support/survey-instrument.html)

1. Mental health outcomes
2. Knowledge of mental health support/resources
3. Utilization of mental health support/resources

### 3.4.1 Instrument for Mental Health Outcomes

The following are 2 validated survey instruments for studying anxiety and depression, respectively: <sup>2</sup>

- GAD-2 (Kroenke et al., 2007)
- PHQ-2 (Kroenke et al., 2003)

Each of them includes only 2 questions, which is advantageous to our application.

## 4 Financial Aid Related Questions

### 4.1 FAFSA Dependency Status

Students might file their FAFSA as depends of their parents when they first enter college, which might result in less financial aid received. However, should their dependency status change (e.g. family stop financially supporting them) during the academic year, they cannot update their dependency status until they refile FAFSA for the next academic year. This means that for the rest of the academic year after the dependency status change, the student will have access to less financial resources and face potential financial difficulties. This can be particularly problematic for LGBTQ students, who may lose family financial support due to coming out.

#### 4.1.1 Sample Instrument: Dependency Status

*Has your dependency status for FAFSA changed during an academic year?*

*If so, what is the reason for the change?*

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<sup>2</sup>See details of these instruments here: <https://www.hiv.uw.edu/page/mental-health-screening/gad-2>

## 4.2 Paying for College

We can reuse the same question from the spring survey to ask students how they are paying for college.

## 4.3 Student Loan Borrowing and Student Debt

Evidence suggests that LGBTQ students face significant student debt burdens <sup>3</sup>. The borrowing habits and debt burden of students is also of general interest.

### 4.3.1 Instrument: Student Debt and Loan Borrowing

- *How much student debt do you currently have?*
- *What is the total amount of student loan that you expect to borrow for college?*

## 4.4 Financial Security

We can use a slightly modified version of the instrument from the spring survey to study financial security.

### 4.4.1 Instrument: Financial Security

*How worried are you about the following?*

- *Paying for food*
- *Paying tuition and fees*
- *Paying rent*
- *Paying for textbook and other school supplies*
- *Paying for transportation*

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<sup>3</sup><https://www.lendingtree.com/student/lgbtq-student-loan-borrowers-survey/>



## 4.5 Food and Housing Security

Food and housing security are important factors that can affect the college experiences and outcomes of students. Studying them can lend insights on disparities among students as well.

### 4.5.1 Instrument: Food Security

The USDA has a validated 6-item survey instrument for studying food security <sup>4</sup>. This instrument is designed for in-person interviews, and we can adapt them accordingly for our online survey.

1. *"The food that (I/we) bought just didn't last, and (I/we) didn't have money to get more." Was that often, sometimes, or never true for (you/your household) in the last 12 months?*
2. *"(I/we) couldn't afford to eat balanced meals." Was that often, sometimes, or never true for (you/your household) in the last 12 months?*
3. *In the last 12 months, since last (name of current month), did (you/you or other adults in your household) ever cut the size of your meals or skip meals because there wasn't enough money for food? (Yes, No, IDK)*
4. *IF YES ABOVE: How often did this happen—almost every month, some months but not every month, or in only 1 or 2 months? (Almost every month, Some months but not every month, Only 1 or 2 months, DK)*
5. *In the last 12 months, did you ever eat less than you felt you should because there wasn't enough money for food? (Yes, No, IDK)*
6. *In the last 12 months, were you every hungry but didn't eat because there wasn't enough money for food? (Yes, No, IDK)*

### 4.5.2 Instrument: Housing Security

The following instruments are taken from the Accountable Health Communities Health-Related Social Needs Screening Tool and the AAFP (American Academy of Family Physicians) Social Needs Screening Tool, respectively. <sup>5</sup>

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<sup>4</sup><https://www.ers.usda.gov/topics/food-nutrition-assistance/food-security-in-the-u-s/survey-tools/>

<sup>5</sup><https://sirennetwork.ucsf.edu/housing-insecurity-instability-homelessness-questions>

1. *What is your living situation today?*

- *I have a steady place to live*
- *I have a place to live today, but I am worried about losing it in the future*
- *I do not have a steady place to live (I am temporarily staying with others, in a hotel, in a shelter, living outside on the street, on a beach, in a car, abandoned building, bus or train station, or in a park)*

2. *Are you worried or concerned that in the next two months you may not have stable housing that you own, rent, or stay in as a part of a household?*

- *Yes*
- *No*

## 5 Demographics

Gender expression and gender identity are distinct, and gender expression in itself might lead to experiencing discrimination and harassment. Including a question on gender expression in the demographics section can help us gain insight into this area.

### 5.1 Instrument: Gender Expression

The following instrument is taken from Gordon et al. (2018):

*A person’s appearance, style, dress, or the way they walk or talk may affect how people describe them. How do you think other people at school would describe you?*

*Response options: seven-point scale from “very feminine” to “very masculine.”*

Responses can be recoded based on respondent sex assigned at birth to create a continuous variable indicating degree of conformity or nonconformity to societal norms of gender expression (range: 1 = most gender conforming, 7 = most gender nonconforming).

## References

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